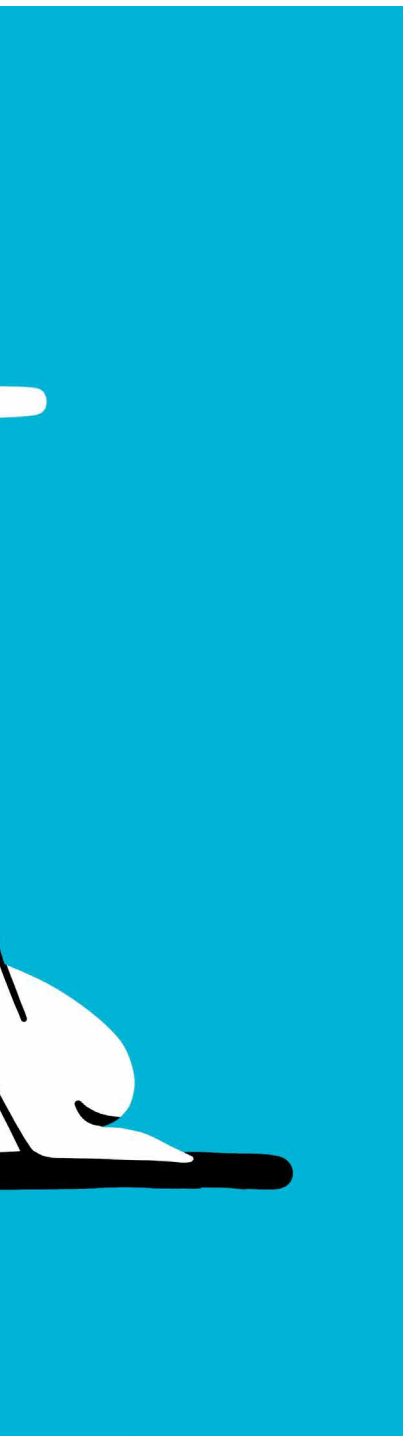
Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE



be open to it. Cross-cultural studies in psychology have shown that women's shyness in sexual matters is socially produced. In countries that have not had a sexual revolution, concerns about gossip, reputation, and maternal socialisation—how women experienced their mothers' views on sex—are thought to be key factors that shape women's bedroom experiences.

The high numbers of women who fake orgasms in 2023 points to the possibility that women still see men as the rightful subjects of the (hetero) sexual dream. That women fake orgasms more suggests that during the sexual experience, they identify more with being pleasing objects—attending to men's needs—than needy subjects. Sex, after all, is not only an arena for the experience of pleasure, it is also the theatre in which individual and relationship identities are enacted. Faking an orgasm performs pleasure while actually renouncing it: the faker may get relationship satisfaction—she has pleased her partner and made him feel secure—but not sexual satisfaction. The orgasm may be fake, but the pleasure in enacting the familiar cultural trope of a hungry man ably hosted by a generous woman may be genuine.

Anxiety about women as sexual subjects is a longstanding theme in patriarchal societies. Sexually agential women are spoilers to the fantasy of heterosexual male sexual power—they remind men that the sexual dream is not a one-person dream of a male satisfied by a female. For both men and women to have their sexual needs satisfied in heterosexuality, the 'woman gives and man takes' equation has to be given up, but the survey results suggest that as a collective, we are reluctant to do so. Both men and women are particularly appalled by the idea of a woman using a sex toy. The Woman Who Pleases Herself is an interloper to a scene that hitherto belonged to The Man Who Must be Pleased.

WOMEN FAKE ORGASMS WHEN THEY SEE THEMSELVES AS PLEASING OBJECTS, NOT NEEDY SUBJECTS

For all genders and sexualities, the survey results on the use of sex toys seem to further illuminate why high sex desire does not translate into high sex demand. That the majority of respondents won't date someone who uses a sex toy, and won't admit to using one, suggests that it is still shameful to admit the truth of sexual pleasure as a necessary force in the human experience. What is the shame associated with being someone who (literally) takes the matter of sex into their own hands? Unlike other arenas of life where independence and self-development are valued, people who use sex toys are seen as at once powerless against the needs of desire and powerful sources of insecurity to their human partners.

Navigating sexual awkwardness is critical to translate sex desire into sex demand. Whether that awkwardness is in bearing the anxiety of rummaging around for a partner's G-spot, facing a partner who might know themselves much better than we do because they use a sex toy, or accepting a partner who might not, eventually, please us as reliably as our toys do, anxiety is an undeniable part of the sexual experience. Without a capacity for sexual awkwardness, we remain locked in a world of sexual fantasy: delicious in its own right, but for many, as the survey results show, insufficiently real. ■

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